

THE BELL BENEATH BRIARWOOD

A first adventure for three heroes

Players: 3 Heroes + 1 Game Master

Difficulty: Beginner

Length: Approximately 2–3 hours

THE ADVENTURE

For hundreds of years, the little village of Briarwood has stood beside an enormous forest.

Every evening at sunset, a bell rings from somewhere deep beneath the trees.

Nobody in Briarwood knows exactly where the bell is.

Nobody remembers who rings it.

But everyone knows one thing:

The bell has never missed a night.

Until yesterday.

Last night, the sun disappeared behind the hills...

and the forest remained silent.

This morning, strange things began happening.

Animals are fleeing the woods.

Blue lights have been spotted between the trees.

And sometime during the night, something enormous left three-toed footprints in the mud outside the village.

The people of Briarwood need heroes.

Unfortunately...

you're the only ones around.

FOR THE GAME MASTER

The truth is not quite as frightening as the villagers believe.

Deep beneath Briarwood Forest lies an ancient underground shrine called The Hollow.

Inside hangs the Bell of Morning, an enchanted silver bell that has quietly protected Briarwood for generations.

Its caretaker is a tiny moss-covered creature named Muddle.

Yesterday, a band of goblins discovered the Hollow.

Their leader, Grubwort, decided that the enormous shiny bell would make an excellent dinner bell for his new goblin kingdom.

The goblins couldn't remove it.

So Grubwort stole the magical crystal inside it instead.

Without the crystal, the bell cannot ring.

Unfortunately, something else lives beneath the Hollow.

Something the bell's magic was keeping asleep.

A creature called the Briar Beast.

The heroes must find the Hollow, discover what happened, recover the crystal, and restore the bell before nightfall.

They can accomplish this in whatever way they can imagine.

PART ONE: BRIARWOOD

The adventure begins in the village square.

Read or describe:

The little village of Briarwood is normally a cheerful place.

Today it isn't.

Doors are shut. Chickens have disappeared beneath wagons. A farmer is standing on a barrel holding a frying pan like a shield.

In the middle of the square, several villagers are gathered around three enormous footprints pressed into the mud.

Each footprint is nearly as long as your arm.

Mayor Pippa Bramblepot, a short woman wearing an extraordinarily tall hat, rushes toward the heroes.

"The bell didn't ring!"

She points dramatically toward the forest.

"The bell ALWAYS rings!"

She then notices that nobody else seems quite as alarmed as she is.

"...This is bad."

What do you do?

Allow the heroes to investigate however they want.

There are several things they might discover.

THE FOOTPRINTS

Examining the tracks reveals something strange.

The footprints are enormous...

but they're strangely shallow.

A successful ***DC 10 Mind or Tracking*** Check reveals that whatever made them wasn't actually very heavy.

Closer examination reveals several smaller goblin footprints surrounding them.

Truth: Three goblins tied giant wooden feet to their boots because Grubwort thought it would frighten the villagers.

It worked.

TALKING TO THE FARMER

Farmer Hobb saw something last night.

He describes:

"Three enormous monsters! At least twenty feet tall! Maybe thirty! With glowing eyes!"

His wife shouts from their house:

"They were goblins wearing buckets on their heads."

Hobb pauses.

"...Very LARGE goblins."

The heroes learn that the creatures disappeared toward the old forest trail.

SEARCHING AROUND

A hero searching near the footprints can find a broken piece of rope and a small wooden sign.

Written on the sign:

PROPERTY OF KING GRUBWORT

Someone has crossed out "King" and written:

EMPEROR

Then someone crossed that out and wrote:

VERY IMPORTANT KING

PART TWO — INTO BRIARWOOD

The forest is enormous.

Ancient trees twist overhead, blocking much of the sunlight.

After following the goblin tracks for a while, the heroes encounter their first obstacle.

The path ends at a rushing stream.

The old wooden bridge has collapsed.

Across the water, the tracks continue into the forest.

Don't immediately suggest a solution.

Ask:

What do you do?

Possible solutions include:

Jumping across.

Climbing a nearby tree.

Making a rope crossing.

Repairing the bridge.

Searching for another route.

Using magic.

Throwing something across.

Helping another hero.

Use **DC 8–12 checks** depending on the idea.

Clever plans may simply work.

Failure should create trouble rather than stop the adventure.

A hero who fails while crossing might fall into the shallow water, lose an item downstream, end up hanging from the bridge, or attract something from the forest.

THE STRANGE LITTLE CREATURE

Not long after crossing the stream, the heroes hear:

"PSST!"

Nothing is there.

"Up here!"

Sitting on a branch is a tiny creature covered in moss, leaves, and mushrooms.

This is Muddle.

Muddle is the caretaker of the Bell of Morning.

He speaks extremely quickly when nervous.

Which is almost always.

"The bell is broken because the shiny bit is gone and the shiny bit is gone because THEY took it and I told them not to take it but apparently shouting 'please don't take that' isn't an effective defensive strategy."

If the heroes calm him down, Muddle explains:

Goblin thieves entered the Hollow.

They stole the Bellheart, a glowing blue crystal that powers the bell.

Muddle followed them but became frightened when he heard something moving beneath the shrine.

He asks the heroes to retrieve it.

Before they leave, he warns:

"If you hear growling beneath the ground..."

He thinks for a moment.

"...don't."

He has no further explanation.

PART THREE — THE GOBLIN CAMP

The heroes eventually discover a small clearing.

Several tents surround a campfire.

A crooked banner hangs between two trees.

It reads:

KINGDOM OF GRUBWORT

Underneath, in smaller letters:

NO HEROES

Someone has added:

PLEASE

Three goblins occupy the camp.

One is cooking.

One is asleep.

The third is wearing a cooking pot as a helmet.

Sitting beside the fire is a small wooden chest.

A faint blue glow shines through its cracks.

The Bellheart is inside.

The heroes need the crystal.

How they get it is entirely up to them.

They could:

Sneak into camp.

Distract the goblins.

Challenge them.

Trade with them.

Pretend to be goblins.

Steal the chest.

Convince the goblins that the crystal is cursed.

Start a fight.

Or invent something completely different.

IF COMBAT BEGINS

Use three Goblins.

HP 5

AC 11

ATK +2

DMG 1d4

Sneaky: +2 when trying to hide.

The goblins are not particularly brave.

If two goblins are defeated, the remaining goblin immediately attempts to surrender.

"WAIT!"

The goblin throws down its weapon.

"We have suddenly remembered that we are pacifists."

The goblins can reveal that Grubwort took the crystal into the old ruins.

Apparently he wants to put it into his crown.

PART FOUR — THE HOLLOW

Following the trail brings the heroes to an enormous stone doorway buried beneath the roots of an ancient tree.

The door stands open.

Beyond it, stone stairs descend underground.

Blue light flickers somewhere below.

Inside, the heroes find enormous carved pictures covering the walls.

They show villagers.

The forest.

The silver bell.

And something enormous sleeping beneath tangled roots.

Then...

BOOOONG.

A terrible metallic noise echoes through the ruins.

Then a voice:

"AGAIN!"

BOOOONG.

"STILL TERRIBLE!"

The heroes have found Grubwort.

KING GRUBWORT

Grubwort stands in the ancient bell chamber.

He is a particularly small goblin sitting on an unusually large wooden throne.

Upon his head is an enormous crown.

Wedge into the front of the crown is the glowing Bellheart.

Grubwort isn't evil.

He's an idiot.

He genuinely believes finding an abandoned underground building makes him its king.

He refuses to surrender the crystal.

"I found it."

He points toward the floor.

"Therefore it belongs to me."

Grubwort will argue, bargain, threaten, negotiate, or challenge the heroes.

This encounter does not have to become a battle.

The heroes might convince him that:

The Bellheart is dangerous.

A king should protect his subjects.

The crystal belongs to Muddle.

There is better treasure somewhere else.

His crown looks ridiculous.

Or something nobody anticipated.

But eventually...

the floor shakes.

Dust falls from the ceiling.

Something enormous grows beneath them.

Grubwort looks down.

"...Was that here before?"

PART FIVE — THE BRIAR BEAST

Roots explode upward through the stone floor.

A huge creature climbs from beneath the chamber.

It resembles an enormous bear made from tangled roots, thorns, leaves, and ancient wood.

Two golden eyes open.

The Briar Beast has awakened.

BRIAR BEAST

Big Bad

HP 24

AC 12

ATK +3

DMG 1d6

THORN SWIPE

When the Briar Beast rolls a natural 20, thorny vines lash outward. Another nearby hero takes 2 damage.

WEAKNESS — THE BELL

The Briar Beast isn't truly evil.

It has been magically sleeping beneath the Hollow for generations.

The Bell of Morning's song keeps it peacefully asleep.

If the heroes return the Bellheart to the bell, they don't have to defeat the creature.

The Bellheart socket is visible across the chamber.

Getting there while the Briar Beast attacks should require clever movement, teamwork, or checks.

Heroes might:

Distract the monster.

Climb over fallen stones.

Throw the Bellheart.

Use Magic Hand.

Hold the monster back.

Lure it away.

Fight it normally.

Ask Grubwort for help.

Or attempt something completely unexpected.

If someone reaches the bell and returns the Bellheart...

Everything becomes silent.

Then:

BOOOOOOOOOOONG.

Golden light fills the chamber.

The Briar Beast freezes.

Its angry golden eyes slowly soften.

It gives an enormous yawn.

Then it curls beneath the ancient roots.

Within moments...

it's snoring.

Grubwort removes his crown.

"...I have reconsidered being king."

THE RETURN TO BRIARWOOD

That evening, the heroes return to the village.

The sun disappears behind the distant hills.

Everyone waits.

For several seconds...

nothing happens.

Then, somewhere deep beneath Briarwood Forest:

BOOOOOOOOOONG.

The Bell of Morning rings again.

The villagers cheer.

Mayor Bramblepot declares the heroes:

OFFICIAL PROTECTORS OF BRIARWOOD

She has absolutely no authority to give them this title.

Nobody mentions that.

TREASURE

As thanks, Muddle gives the heroes an unusual little object he found inside the Hollow.

THE BELLSTONE

A smooth silver stone containing a tiny glowing symbol of a bell.

Once per adventure, a hero holding the Bellstone may ring it to give every hero Advantage on their next roll.

The stone also has another strange property.

Sometimes...

when danger is nearby...

it rings by itself.

Very quietly.

ding.

THE FINAL SCENE

Several days later...

The Bellstone sits quietly among the heroes' belongings.

Then:

ding.

A pause.

ding.

Then again.

ding.

Outside, something moves past the window.

And somewhere beyond Briarwood...

far beyond the forest...

another bell answers.

BOOOOOONG.

But this bell sounds nothing like the Bell of Morning.

And Muddle has already told the heroes something important.

There isn't supposed to be another bell.

THE END